

MAJOR PASHTUN TRIBES

Durrani Ghilzai Yusufzai Afridi Khattak Orakzai

The Pashtun world is not one tribe. It is a vast network of tribes, clans, lineages, confederations, and communities spread across a broad historical geography.

Some groups became prominent through political power, others through population, territory, trade, military organization, local influence, or historical importance. Their histories overlap, and their genealogies sometimes connect them through traditional descent structures. But each community also developed its own local history. To speak of “the Pashtuns” therefore requires remembering the diversity within the name.

A MAP OF DIVERSITY

Across the historical Pashtun world, several major tribal groupings and communities are frequently discussed in historical and ethnographic literature, including the Durrani, Ghilzai, Yusufzai, Afridi, Khattak, Mohmand, Orakzai, Shinwari, Achakzai, Bangash, Wazir, Mehsud, Marwat, Bettani, and numerous other clans and regional communities.¹

This list is not exhaustive, nor do all scholars use identical classifications. The Pashtun tribal landscape is dynamic and far larger than any single catalog.

DURRANI AND GHILZAI CONFEDERATIONS

The Durrani confederation (historically associated with the older name Abdali) is one of the most prominent political groupings in Afghan history, comprising major tribal branches such as the Popalzai, Barakzai, Alikozai, and Achakzai. Their prominence expanded significantly following the rise of Ahmad Shah Durrani in the eighteenth century.²

The Ghilzai (or Ghilji) form another major tribal confederation historically associated with eastern and southeastern Afghanistan. Their extensive political and social history demonstrates that Pashtun leadership and heritage cannot be reduced to a single dynasty or region.

REGIONAL TRIBES: YUSUFZAI, AFRIDI AND KHATTAK

The Yusufzai are majorly established in the northwestern areas of present-day Pakistan, particularly around Swat, Buner, and Malakand, with a rich history of migration, settlement, and regional administration.³

The Afridi are historically associated with the mountainous terrain surrounding the Khyber Pass, serving a vital strategic role in connecting Afghanistan and South Asia. Similarly, the Khattak have a distinguished history of political organization and literary culture across Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, famously represented by the warrior-poet Khushal Khan Khattak.⁴

THE ORAKZAI PLACE IN THE TRIBAL LANDSCAPE

The Orakzai are a major Pashtun tribal community historically associated with the mountainous Tirah region and adjoining areas in northwestern Pakistan. Possessing their own internal subdivisions, genealogical traditions, and historical narratives, the Orakzai illustrate how distinct tribal identities thrive within the broader Pashtun world.⁵

As established throughout this work, tribal identity is not a static museum object. Through migration, urbanization, education, and digital connectivity, Pashtuns in global cities maintain deep cultural ties to their ancestral heritage while contributing to the modern world.

CONFEDERATION · TRIBE · CLAN · LINEAGE

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Studying the vast tapestry of Pashtun tribes reminds us that unity and diversity are not opposites. The Durrani, Ghilzai, Yusufzai, Afridi, Khattak, Orakzai, and countless other communities each possess distinct histories, yet all contribute to the shared heritage of the

Pashtun world. Understanding this network deepens our respect for where we came from and where we are going.